Revision Date
08/01/2024

Background:
All CalFresh household (HH) members are required to provide a Social Security Number (SSN) or apply for one prior to certification.

Purpose:
This section details the SSN requirements for individuals applying for CalFresh. It includes updated guidance on referring individuals to the Social Security Administration (SSA) when they do not have a SSN and are required to apply for one.

Policy:
Prior to certification, applicants are required to provide the SSN or verification of application for a SSN for each HH member. If an individual has more than one SSN all numbers are required to be provided. Explain to the HH that failure/refusal to provide a SSN without good cause will result in ineligibility of the individual for whom the SSN was not provided.

Note: The SSN requirement does not apply to individuals in the HH who are not requesting CalFresh, are undocumented, or noncitizens opting out.

1. Validating/Verifying the SSN

A Social Security Card is not required to be provided; a verbal or written statement of the SSN is sufficient. All SSNs must be verified/validated through the Income Eligibility Verification System (IEVS). An applicant IEVS is automatically requested by CalSAWS when a case is pended in the system if the applicant's name, date of birth, and SSN are entered. If an applicant IEVS is not automatically generated, request one to verify/validate the SSN. The issuance of benefits shall not be delayed, if otherwise eligible, while pending a response from IEVS. However, the IEVS report must be processed within 45 days of receipt. If the SSN has already been verified/validated by a previous IEVS then no additional verification is needed.

The table below details the SSN verification codes that may be accepted to verify/validate a SSN and the actions to take if an acceptable SSN verification is not received.

If the SSN verification code is…	**then…**
"A" or "W" in MEDS or "J" on the IEVS report,	the SSN is validated/verified. No further verification/clarification is needed.
anything other than "A" or "W" in MEDS or "J" in IEVS, **Note:** Refer to CalSAWS Tip	there is either a data mismatch (the name and/or date of birth does not match that associated with the SSN) or the SSN validation/verification failed. Contact the HH to clarify the individual's name, date of birth, and SSN are correct. If unable to resolve the data mismatch with the HH, issue a Request for Verification (CW 2200) and allow them 10 days to provide verification from the SSA that the data mismatch has been

MEDS SSN for more information on each SSN verification code.	resolved. A Social Security Administration Referral Notice (MC 194) may be provided to the customer to bring to SSA to complete. Once the verification/clarification has been received, update CalSAWS and manually request another applicant IEVS to verify/validate the SSN; CalSAWS will not automatically request another applicant IEVS when demographic information is updated.

Note: Individuals should be entered into the eligibility determination system under the exact name associated with their SSN to avoid data mismatches.

2. Exemption for Expedited Services (ES)

HHs eligible for ES are not required to provide or apply for a SSN until after they have received their first allotment. HHs eligible for ES with postponed verifications must provide the missing SSN(s) or verification of an application for a SSN before the next issuance. The next issuance could be the second month for HHs applying before the 15th of the month or the third month for HHs applying after the 15th of the month.

3. Exemption for Victims of Trafficking, Domestic Violence, or Other Serious Crimes

Noncitizens who are victims of trafficking, domestic violence, or other serious crimes do not have to provide or apply for a SSN as a condition of eligibility for state funded benefits (California Food Assistance Program [CFAP]). Once the trafficking victim has been certified by the Office of Refugee Resettlement (ORR), they will be eligible for federal benefits (CalFresh) and are required to provide/apply for a SSN.

4. Newborns

HHs reporting a newborn in the home may not have a SSN for the newborn at the time the report is made. If the customer cannot self-attest or provide proof of an application for a SSN at the time the newborn is reported in the home, the newborn will be eligible to CalFresh until the HHs next recertification or the sixth month following the child's birth, whichever is later.

The table below details when the SSN or verification of application for a SSN must be provided for a newborn.

If the sixth month is…	then the SSN, application for a SSN, or good cause must be provided …
after the HH's recertification and the SSN or application for SSN was not provided at recertification,	by the end of the sixth month otherwise the child is ineligible starting the seventh month.
before the HH's recertification,	at recertification otherwise the child is ineligible starting the first month of the new certification period.

5. Obtaining a SSN

HH members who qualify for, but do not have a SSN are required to apply for one. Assist in obtaining a SSN by:

- Providing them with one of the following to bring to the SSA to apply for a SSN:

If the individual is a….	then provide them with…
United States (US) citizen, legal permanent resident (LPR), refugee, asylee, or any other qualified noncitizen status with authorization to work in the US,	a Social Security Administration Referral Notice (MC 194) to bring to SSA when applying for a SSN. **Note**: An MC 194 is not required to be brought to SSA to apply for a SSN. Inform customers that they do not need to wait for the form to go apply.
qualified noncitizen without authorization to work in the US; does not have an I-766 Employment Authorization Document (EAD) or a pending application for an EAD,	a Non-Work Social Security Number Request form (GEN 2101). The GEN 2101 must be completed by the Human Services Specialist (HSS) **and** signed by a Family Resource Center (FRC) Manager to be considered valid.

- Providing the address of the local SSA office.
- Informing the customer of the documentation the SSA will need, such as identity and verification of US citizenship or noncitizen status.
- Assisting in obtaining documents required by the SSA to apply for an SSN.

Verification an application for a SSN was submitted includes, but is not limited to:

- MC 194 with Part II completed by the SSA office.
- Form SSA 5028 (receipt of application for an SSN from the SSA).
- Form SSA-2853-OP4 (receipt showing that the parent has requested a SSN for the newborn at the hospital).
- Form I-765 Application for Employment Authorization if the applicant has consented on the form to disclose their information to the SSA for purposes of obtaining a SSN. Questions 14 and 15 marked as “Yes” indicate the applicant is requesting a SSN.

6. Failure/Refusal to Comply with SSN Requirement

HH members who fail/refuse to provide a SSN, apply for one, or resolve a data mismatch without good cause, will be ineligible until compliance occurs. Ineligibility applies only to the HH member whose SSN was not provided and not the entire HH. Compliance occurs when one of the following is provided:

- Their SSN.
- Verification of application for a SSN.
- Verification the SSN mismatch was resolved.
- Good cause.

Note: For guidance on treatment of income and expenses of SSN disqualified individuals refer to Section 63-255 Treatment of Income and Expenses of Ineligible and Non-Household Members.

7. Good Cause Determination for Not Providing a SSN

Determine if good cause exists for failure to comply with the SSN requirements. When determining good cause, consider the information provided by the customer and the SSA. Documentary evidence or collateral information that the customer has applied for a SSN or made every effort to supply the

SSA with the necessary information to apply, will be considered good cause. Good cause does not include delays due to illness, lack of transportation, or temporary absences.

If the individual can show good cause why an application for a SSN has not been completed in a timely manner, that individual will be allowed to participate for one month in addition to the month of application. Good cause must be shown on a monthly basis for the individual to continue to receive CalFresh benefits. If they fail to provide their SSN, application for a SSN, or do not continue to show good cause on a monthly basis, the individual will become ineligible.

References:
Manual of Policy and Procedures (MPP) 63-404, 63-403.211; Code of Federal Regulations (CFR) 273.6; All County Informational Notice (ACIN) I-54-22, I-54-01; All County Letter (ACL) 07-45, 07-45E, 24-44; MEDS Network User Manual.

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance on or by 07/31/2027.

Approval for Release:

8/16/24

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Self-Sufficiency Services